
4.5 Unit 4, Topic C: Governing the USA

Focus This topic examines the institutional framework of US government and considers the interrelationships between its legislative, executive and judicial processes and the health of US federalism.

What students need to learn: ***Students taking Unit 4, Topic C must learn all areas within the topic.***

The Constitution

Key concepts	Content explanation
separation of powers checks and balances Constitutional rights	■ A knowledge of the nature and principles of the US Constitution. ■ An awareness of the constitutional framework within which US institutions operate and of the relationship between the Constitution and practical politics. ■ Constitutional rights and an evaluation of their effectiveness.

Congress

Key concepts	Content explanation
representation government gridlock the committee system of Congress	■ A knowledge of the structure and workings of Congress, of the distribution of power within Congress, and of debates about the adequacy of its representative role. ■ A knowledge of factors influencing the relationship between Congress and the presidency, and an ability to discuss the policy significance and institutional effectiveness of Congress. ■ An awareness of the extent and significance of party allegiance.

Presidency

Key concepts	Content explanation
presidential system imperial presidency Executive Office of the President (EXOP) Cabinet Federal Bureaucracy new federalism	■ A knowledge of the formal and informal sources of presidential power and of the relationships between the presidency and other institutions. ■ An awareness of the factors that affect the role of the presidency and an ability to evaluate the capacity to provide leadership of the presidency and of recent presidents.

Supreme Court

Key concepts	Content explanation
judicial review judicial independence due process	■ A knowledge of the composition and role of the Supreme Court. ■ A knowledge of the process for appointing Federal judges and of debates about the political significance of the Supreme Court and its impact on public policy in the USA.